

The Wurm That Devoured Heaven

Book One — The Runt and the Word

Chapter One

Hatched

His brother poisoned Vale Corren at eleven forty-seven on a Tuesday, and the first thought Vale had when he realized it was, *of course*.

The wine was a Veranne '78. His brother had chosen it. His brother had chosen the meeting place too — a private dining room on the forty-second floor of a building Vale had bought three years ago and put in his brother's name for tax reasons.

There was a kind of poetry in dying inside your own building, under your own name. Vale had spent his adult life carving advantages out of people who underestimated him; he appreciated poetry the way other men appreciated knives. Both were tools. Both could open a thing up.

The convulsion arrived between the third and fourth glass. His fingers stopped being his. He set the glass down with the deliberate care of a man who had rehearsed losing things, and looked across the table at his brother.

Eric was crying. Not from grief. From the surgical brightness of what he was about to inherit. Vale recognized the expression. He had worn it once himself, at twenty-two, the day he had ruined their father.

"You," Vale said, and meant a great many things by it. His tongue had begun to fail. The word came out flat, useless.

Eric reached across the table and took the wineglass from his dying brother's hand with the same gentleness their mother had used to lift a thorn from a paw. "I know," he said. "I know. I'm sorry. I had to."

In the last clean minute of his life, Vale did the math. The shares. The shell companies. The accountant in Boston. The accountant's wife, who was a notary. The notary who had certified Eric's signature on three documents Vale had never seen.

He had been watching the front of the house, and someone had walked in the back, and the someone had been the only person in the world he had not been watching, because the someone had been the only person in the world he had loved.

He laughed. It came out as a thin red gurgle, and Eric flinched, and Vale loved that flinch the way a dying soldier loves the last small wound he gets to give.

Then the room went out, like a candle in a draft, and Vale Corren stopped being.



He did not stop being for long.

There is a dark that is not the absence of light. It is the absence of *being looked at*. It is the dark a thing falls into when nothing in the universe is currently considering it.

Vale fell into that dark, and was aware of falling, which was not the standard arrangement.

He had time to be embarrassed. Forty-one years constructing a man who could not be surprised, and here he was, surprised. Somewhere in the falling he had time to be afraid as well. He set the fear down on a high shelf to come back for later, the way he set down most feelings.

Then text appeared in the dark.

☒ **ASSESSMENT** ☒

- > SOUL RECOVERED.
- > CLASSIFICATION: ANOMALOUS.
- > SOUL WEIGHT: NON-STANDARD.
- > SOUL TENSILE: HIGH.
- > SOUL ORIGIN: NOT FROM THIS WORLD.
- > ...
- > REROUTING.

Vale read it with the dispassion of a man reading a memo about himself in the third person.

More text followed.

☒ **INHERITANCE PROTOCOL** ☒

- > AVAILABLE VESSEL DETECTED.
- > VESSEL TYPE: DRACONIC, JUVENILE, PRE-HATCH.
- > VESSEL CONDITION: DEFECTIVE (RUNT).
- > ETHICAL OBJECTIONS: NONE FILED.
- > CONSENT: NOT REQUIRED.
- > BINDING.

"Wait," Vale said, into the dark, with a mouth he no longer had. "Wait — *consent?*"

The dark did not wait. The dark had never waited for anyone. The text scrolled past him like a verdict, and the next thing Vale Corren knew was that something was *squeezing* him.



It was wet. It was hot. It was, in the part of his brain that still worked, an extraordinary humiliation, because Vale Corren was unmistakably a fetus.

Forty-one years of careful self-construction, about to be relitigated by something the size of a soup bowl.

His body was wrong. Too many joints. The joints in the wrong order. Something at the small of his back twitched that should not have been there at all. Something behind his shoulders was folded so tight against him that the muscles of his sides ached in unfamiliar patterns.

He could move only the way a folded letter can move. A little, and in the direction of the fold.

A heart hammered in him, fast and small and far too forward in his chest. Not a heart he knew. He listened to it for what could have been minutes or hours — there was no other entertainment — and tried to inventory what he was.

Smooth surface, curved, on every side. Yielding when he pressed with what he was beginning to suspect were claws. Warm. Warmer than him.

Warmer, surely, than the air outside, which meant he lay beneath something. A body. A bigger body.

He could hear it now: the slow ponderous *thoom-thoom* of another heart, much larger, muffled by layers of him and shell and flesh.

Mother, he thought, with the cold neutrality of a man cataloguing an asset.

Something came through the shell. Not a voice — a *sense*. The impression of a voice. The weight of an enormous attention passing over him the way a searchlight passes over a field.

The attention paused. The attention dismissed him. The attention moved on to something else, and Vale understood, the way one understands the temperature of a room, that he had been weighed and found wanting.

He had been weighed and found wanting before. He had built a fortune out of it. For the first time since the wine, he felt something close to comfort.

Then the text came back.

⌘ **STATUS — INITIALIZING** ⌘

NAME: [unassigned]

RACE: Dragon (Hatchling, pre-emergence)

SUBTYPE: Bronze-line; recessive Ashen marker

STAGE: 0 — HATCHLING

AGE: 0 (in-shell)

VIT: 2

STR: 1

AGI: 3

END: 2

INT: 16

WIS: 14

WORD: 1 (untriggered)

FREE STAT POINTS: 0

SKILLS: none

TITLES: [Soul Out Of Place]

WORDS HELD: 1 / 1 ([sealed])

Vale, in the shell, blinked. He didn't yet have eyelids he could feel, but the impulse was there, and some other membrane he hadn't known about clicked obediently.

He read the slate again. He read it a third time. With the same dispassion he had once used to note that his brother had touched the Boston account, he marked the imbalance: INT and WIS very high. Everything else abysmal.

The slate responded to his attention the way a screen responds to a cursor. There was a slot called WORD. The slot was sealed. Whatever lived in there was apparently his.

Show me my title, he thought, very deliberately.

The slate obliged.

☒ **TITLE — [SOUL OUT OF PLACE]** ☒

Origin: Anomalous reincarnation.

Effect 1: INT and WIS retain prior-life values.

(Detected: high. Retention complete.)

Effect 2: System interface readable in language
of origin.

Effect 3: All other beings of this world will,
on some level, find you WRONG.

Trust must be earned, not inherited.

This title cannot be removed.

He read the third effect twice, and tried to laugh. What came out, inside the shell, against the warm wet wall of the egg, was a thin reedy *kek-kek-kek* that startled him by being his.

All other beings of this world will find me wrong, Vale thought, in the language of his old life. *That isn't new. That's Tuesday.*

He set the slate aside. It dimmed. He went to work.

☒ ☒ ☒

Vale Corren had not survived forty-one years of being the smartest boy in a room full of bigger boys by panicking. He had survived by triage.

Triage now. He was small. He was weak. He was inside a shell. Outside the shell was a mother who had already dismissed him. Outside the shell, almost certainly, were siblings.

He didn't know much about dragons. From the cheap fantasy novels his nephew had loved, he knew dragon broods were violent. From nature documentaries watched in hotel rooms in cities whose names he no longer remembered, he knew birds did not all hatch at once.

The first one out ate the most. The last one out, often, didn't eat at all.

He explored the inside of his shell with claws he was only beginning to know he had, and found a thin place. Above him, at the top of the curve. Of course. The egg had been resting with that spot up; the shell was thinnest where it had been least compressed against the nest.

He filed the observation. He suspected he'd be filing many such observations soon.

The question wasn't *could* he hatch. The question was *when*.

He had been good, in his old life, at thinking about *when*. Market timing. Press releases. The exact half-second of a board meeting at which a particular piece of information would do the most damage. Timing had

been his religion.

Now. Through the shell, he could feel the heat-shapes of other eggs around him. Three. No — four. One very close. One across the nest. Two clustered together.

Faint scrabblings came from two of them. Already hatching. The one directly beside him hadn't begun. It might be slower. It might be smaller. It might be the only thing in the nest he could reasonably hope to *not* be eaten by.

I should hatch last, he thought.

If I hatch last, I will be the smallest. The mother will not bother to feed me first. The others will eat first. The others will be stronger. The others will eat me.

I should hatch first.

If I hatch first I will be wet and blind and trembling in a nest of unbroken eggs. The mother will see me and weigh me and find me wanting again. The next thing she weighs me against will be the strong one. The strong one will come out a quarter-hour later. I will be eaten in a quarter-hour.

He thought, with the calm of a man who had done this kind of thinking many times before:

I should hatch second.

I should hatch right behind whoever comes out first, while the mother is still distracted by them. I should hatch with my eyes open. I should hatch already moving.

He pressed his shoulder against the thin place at the top of his shell. He did not push. Not yet. He waited.

And while he waited, in the dark, the slate hummed at the edge of his attention, like a friend with something to say.



It came as a crack.

Not his crack. Someone else's. A clean splintering, transmitted through warm shell and nest-stuff, from the egg across the cluster. A wet shriek followed it — high, thin, triumphant in a way nothing alive for less than a minute had any right to be.

And then the mother.

The huge heart sped. The huge body shifted. The world tilted as she rose, and Vale, in his tilted shell, knew without seeing it that her enormous attention had landed on the shrieker. Pouring onto the shrieker. *All* of it.

Now, he thought.

He pushed.

He had no idea how to push. Three minutes ago he had been a man in a building. He pushed anyway — with everything that ached in him, with the curl of his too-many joints and the twitch at the small of his back and the folded ache between his shoulders.

The shell at the thin place did not so much crack as *peel* — a long curl of it lifting away like skin off a fruit.

Cold air.

Cold air on a thing that had never been cold.

The shock was so total that for half a second Vale forgot he had a plan. He simply *was*, and being was agony. Then the plan came back like a slap, and he gave himself the order in clean dry mental capitals:

OPEN YOUR EYES. NOW.

He opened them.

And saw the world.

☒ ☒ ☒

The nest was a bowl of black volcanic stone, lined with what he took for straw until, a heartbeat later, he understood it was hair — long coarse hair from many animals, woven and matted through with old blood.

The bowl was huge, and set into the floor of a cavern whose ceiling he couldn't see. Heat came off the walls. Light came off the walls — a low, sullen, orange light, the color of a coal that has been kept alive a long time.

Above him: *her*.

Vale had spent a great deal of money in his old life to see things other men did not see. He had stood in the private rooms of museums after closing. He had watched a horse die from six inches away because a man with too much money had wanted him to. He had thought himself, in his quietly prideful way, a man who could not be made to gape.

He gaped now.

She was the size of a house. Not a big house. A reasonable house. Her scales were bronze going green at the edges, like old coins, and her wings — folded — made a ribbed cathedral of shadow over half the nest.

Her eyes were the color of molten glass.

She was looking, fixedly, at his sibling.

His sibling was beautiful.

His sibling was three times his size already, wet and shining the color of new copper, with wing-stubs that pulsed and a head that was turning even now, blind and certain, toward the warm presence of the mother.

The sibling shrieked again, and the mother answered with a pleased low noise — a noise so deep that Vale felt it in his ribs.

Vale did not shriek.

Vale — wet and trembling and the dull color of an unpolished penny — did the only intelligent thing available to a creature like him in a situation like this.

He lay *still*.

He let the broken shell fall around him to hide most of him. He pressed his belly into the hair-matting until he was warmer than the air, until his outline melted into the background heat of the nest. He kept his breathing shallow. He kept his eyes half-lidded so the slick wet of them wouldn't catch the light. He kept the slate dim at the back of his mind.

And he watched.

The mother lowered her great head to the shrieker. Her tongue, black and surprisingly delicate, touched the shrieker's snout. The shrieker shuddered with the joy of being known.

The mother made a sound that was, unmistakably and unsettlingly, a *word* — a single low syllable that rolled out of her throat into the bones of the cave and shook loose grit off the nest-rim.

The shrieker's wing-stubs twitched in answer.

She had named it.

Vale didn't know how he knew that. He knew.

The slate at the back of his mind hummed once, politely, like a butler clearing his throat, and Vale gave it his attention.

⌘ **ENVIRONMENTAL NOTE** ⌘

A WORD has been spoken in your presence.

WORD detected: [unintelligible to listener].

Listener Word-rank: 0.

Your own sealed WORD has responded.

Seal integrity: 99.9%.

(The thing in your throat
has heard its kin.)

He felt it then. A small, bright, terrible warmth at the base of his neck — the way a tongue feels when it has, at last, found the right word for something.

He swallowed by reflex, and the warmth went down with him. Banked. Waiting.

The thing in my throat, he thought, has heard its kin.

He filed that too.



It happened faster than he had budgeted for.

The two clustered eggs broke almost together. The far egg followed a heartbeat later. Three more siblings — all larger than him, all of them red or copper or molten orange, all of them *loud*.

They writhed out of their shells with the gross competence of newborn predators. Within seconds, two of them had already begun biting each other — small testing nips, accompanied by trills of outrage.

The mother surveyed them. Her head moved in long slow arcs.

Vale, motionless in his nest of broken shell, watched her tongue touch each of them in turn. He watched her speak each of their names. Four low syllables. Four shudders in the cave. Four wing-twitches of

recognition.

She came to the place where he was.

She paused.

Her enormous head tilted. The molten-glass eye on his side of her face fixed on him, on whatever it could make out of him beneath the shell-shards, and for one bad airless second Vale Corren — strategist, killer, dead man — was held in a gaze that did not, with absolute clarity, see *him*.

It saw a defect. A bad stitch in a long pattern. A thing that should be tidied.

She lowered her head.

Her tongue slid out, black and delicate, and touched him on the ridge above his eye.

He didn't flinch. He let her touch him. He let her smell whatever she smelled. He kept his mind *boring* — a discipline he had not known he had — held his thoughts in the shape of a sleepy newborn, kept the slate dark, kept the warm thing in his throat *down*.

She spoke.

Not the round low syllables she had given the others. A short word. An exhaled word. One syllable that landed on him like the flat of a hand:

Ashk.

The cave didn't shake. The nest-grit didn't stir. The word settled on him without weight, and Vale understood — the way one understands one's grade has been entered — that he had been named, and that the name was a small one, and that the name meant something close to *ash*.

Leftover. The cold thing at the bottom of the fire.

The slate confirmed it.

☒ NAMING ☒

You have been named by a parent.

NAME: Ashk

Meaning (Wyrms-tongue, low register):

"ash. leftover. cold remnant of fire."

Mocking. A name given to runts to discourage attachment by either parent or sibling.

TITLE acquired: [The Unburnt]

Effect: While this name is borne, hostility from kin is reduced by a small amount.

(They have already decided you do not matter.)

(A name given by another is not yours.

A name you choose is. Remember this.)

He read the parenthetical at the bottom three times.

It was the first thing in this new world that had spoken to him as a peer. The slate, in some sense he couldn't yet measure, was on his side.

Anything *on his side* was probably also a thing that could be a trap, and he would think about that later.

For now, he had been named Ashk. *The Unburnt. The cold thing at the bottom of the fire.*

Vale Corren, who had been called many things in his old life and had hated almost all of them, lay still in his nest of shell-shards and thought, with a small dry private satisfaction:

I will allow it. For now. Mother.

You will live to regret it.



The mother withdrew her tongue. The mother withdrew her attention.

The weight of her not-looking-at-him lifted off him like a blanket pulled back, and Vale, for the first time since the wine, drew a full breath.

The newborns were already squabbling. Two of them had locked jaws over a piece of the mother's offered meat — she had brought something into the nest, something dark and slick and large, and torn it open for them with one bored swipe of a claw.

The bronze one — the first hatcher, the shrieker, the favored — ate with the joyless efficiency of an animal that had already decided to be the biggest.

The others tore at the edges of what was left.

Nothing had been brought to Vale.

He understood, with the same clean dispassion he had once used for quarterly earnings, that nothing would be.

He waited. He watched. He counted the bites. He marked which sibling chewed and which one swallowed whole, which tucked its tail when it ate, which exposed its throat, which favored its left foreleg.

When the shrieker — the bronze one, the bright one — turned to snap at a smaller sibling, Vale caught a soft spot just under the angle of its jaw, where the new scales hadn't yet hardened.

He filed it. Slot one, in a brain that had once held the seating chart of every board he had served on, with the strengths and weaknesses of every man at the table.

The slate hummed.

⌘ **FIRST ASSESSMENT COMPLETE** ⌘

Welcome to AETHERMOOR, Inheritor.

You have survived the first 11 minutes of
your second life. This is longer than 41%
of your kind manage.

OBJECTIVE (Hidden, Tier 1):

SURVIVE THE NEST.

Reward: +1 stage. Free name. Departure
permitted.

OBJECTIVE (Optional, Tier 1):

Identify which sibling will try to kill
you first.

Reward: +3 INT, +1 skill slot.

Hint: it has already looked at you twice.

Vale let his half-lidded eyes track, slowly, around the nest.

The bronze one was eating. The far one had curled into the mother's
flank, asleep. The two near-twins had been squabbling — until a

moment ago.

One of them had stopped.

The smaller of the pair, copper going to red, had pulled back from the squabble and lost interest in its sibling. It was not eating. It was not sleeping.

It was looking at him.

It had been looking at him, Vale realized, since it had pulled itself out of its shell. Once when it had first opened its eyes — and dismissed him. A second time, after the mother had named him — and *not* dismissed him.

It was looking at him with the slow consideration of a creature working out whether a thing was worth the effort of killing.

Vale, in the wet shadow of his broken shell, did not move.

He waited until the copper one looked away, bored, finally, by his stillness.

Then, in the privacy of his own skull, he smiled. Not a dragon's smile — he didn't yet have the face for one.

It was the smile of a forty-one-year-old man who had just identified, in a room full of enemies, the one he was going to deal with first.

You, he thought, at the copper hatchling across the nest. *You first, then.*
I see you.

He thought, almost gently: *Try.*

The slate, in the back of his mind, gave one small chime of approval and dimmed itself, like a good butler stepping out of the room.

Vale Corren — Ashk, the Unburnt, runt of a clutch of five in a cave whose name he didn't know, on a continent whose name he didn't know, in a world whose gods had walked away and left their power in the bones of the ground — closed his eyes the rest of the way, settled his too-many joints into the matted hair of the nest, and went to sleep.

He had work to do in the morning.

— *end of Chapter One* —